EMAIL TEMPLATES

The Rate Guide — Freelancer's Contract Pack

Five situations every working freelancer faces. Written in plain language — not corporate, not groveling.

HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

Each template has a subject line, body, and notes on when and how to use it. Customize the `[BRACKETS]` before sending. The goal is an email that sounds like you — direct, professional, and unafraid of money.

Delete all annotation text (this intro and the `> notes`) before sending.

EMAIL 1 — RATE INTRODUCTION / PROJECT PITCH

Use this when: You're responding to an inquiry and need to introduce your rate before a client asks, or you want to set expectations before the official quote.

Why send it: Clients who aren't prepared for your rate will say yes on the call and ghost on the contract. This email surfaces the number early and filters out the wrong clients before you invest more time.

Subject: `[Your Name]` — `[Role]` — `[Project Name or Type]`

Hi `[Name]`,

Thanks for reaching out. Happy to discuss `[the project / the role / working together]`.

A few quick questions to make sure I can give you an accurate quote:

- What are the shoot dates and location?
- What's the expected scope for post-production, if any?

My day rate is \$ **[Amount]** for [role] work. [Add one sentence of context if helpful: "That's inclusive of my camera package." / "Post is billed separately as a project rate." / "Rates for commercial work differ from my indie rate — happy to discuss."]

Once I have answers to the above, I'll put together a full quote within 24 hours.

[Your Name]

> ***Notes:***
>
> *State your rate in this email. Not a range. Not "it depends." The number.*
>
> *Rates are not a secret. Clients have budgets. By stating your rate early, you respect both your time and theirs. If your rate is outside their budget, better to know in email than on the 45-minute call you just scheduled.*
>
> *The questions serve two purposes: you need the information to quote accurately, and they move the client to action rather than leaving the ball in a vague "let me know if you're interested" zone.*

EMAIL 2 — RATE INCREASE ANNOUNCEMENT

Use this when: You're raising your rate for the new year, after a significant experience milestone, or after a market adjustment. Send to existing clients before they book you at the old rate.

Why send it: Surprising a longtime client with a higher rate mid-booking is awkward. This email gives them advance notice, frames the increase as professional growth, and gives them a window to book at the current rate if they have upcoming work. It is a business communication, not an apology.

Subject: Rate Update — Effective [Date]

Hi [Name],

I wanted to give you a heads-up before you plan any upcoming projects: my day rate for [role] work is increasing

> **DECISION** *Add 1–2 sentences of context if you want to. You don't have to explain yourself, but context can soften the message for longtime clients. Examples:*

- *"This reflects my current market rate after* `[X years]` *of* `[type of work]` *experience."*
- *"I've been holding my rate steady since* `[year]`*, and this brings it in line with current market rates."*

If you have any projects coming up before `[effective date]`, I'm happy to hold the current rate of **\$** **`[Current Rate]`** for those bookings.

`[Your Name]`

> ***Notes:***

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> *The subject line says "Rate Update" — not "My Rate is Going Up" or "Important News." Neutral language keeps the tone professional rather than apologetic.*

>

> *No multi-paragraph justification. No "I've been giving this a lot of thought." State the new rate, the effective date, and the courtesy holdback offer. That's the whole email.*

>

> *Send this 4–6 weeks before the effective date. This gives clients time to plan, and the holdback offer at the current rate often generates early bookings — which is a bonus.*

>

> *If a client responds badly to a professional rate increase notice, that is data about the client.*

EMAIL 3 — LATE PAYMENT FOLLOW-UP

Use this when: An invoice is past due and the client hasn't responded to the initial "just checking in" nudge. This is the follow-up with teeth.

Why send it: Accounts payable departments operate on deadlines. They will not pay a late invoice without prompting — not because they're bad people, but because they're busy and the squeaky wheel gets the grease. This email is the squeak.

Subject: Invoice # `[INV-XXX]` — Past Due — `[Project Name]`

Hi `[Name]`,

Invoice # `[INV-XXX]` for `$[Amount]` was due on `[Due Date]` and remains unpaid as of today.

Per our agreement, late fees of `[1.5%]` /month are now accruing on the outstanding balance.

Can you confirm payment status and an expected payment date?

`[Your Name]`

> ***Notes:***

>

> *Short. Four sentences. That is intentional.*

>

> *Reference the invoice number and the specific amount. This forces a real response — "which invoice are you talking about?" is not a valid deflection when you've named it.*

>

> *The late fee line is not a threat — it's a contractual notification. You're not being aggressive; you're doing your job. If you included a late fee clause in your contract, reference it without apology.*

>

> *If this email also doesn't get a response within 5 business days, escalate: CC their company's general inbox (billing@ or accounts@), or contact the person who originally hired you and ask them to help move the invoice through internally. Most late payments resolve at this stage without legal action.*

>

> *If the amount is significant (varies by your tolerance, typically $1,000+) and you've exhausted follow-ups, small claims court is a real option in most states and does not require a lawyer. The contract and this email chain are your evidence.*

EMAIL 4 — SCOPE CREEP PUSHBACK

Use this when: A client asks you to do something that wasn't in the contract, via email or chat — casually, as if it were obviously included. This is scope creep.

Why send it: The majority of scope creep is not malicious — clients often don't track what was and wasn't in the contract. A professional, non-confrontational response that invokes the Change Order process usually resolves it cleanly. The key is not to just say yes and silently absorb the extra work.

Subject: Re: `[Their original email subject]`

Hi `[Name]`,

Happy to take care of `[the requested change]`.

That's outside our original scope — the contract covers `[what was originally agreed, briefly]`. I'll put together a Change Order for this and send it over `[today / by end of day]` before we get started.

`[If it's a small ask and you want to be generous:]` If the scope on future projects is likely to include this type of work, we can factor it into the quote upfront.

`[Your Name]`

> ***Notes:***

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> *The tone is cooperative, not adversarial. "Happy to take care of it" signals yes — the Change Order is just the process for doing it right.*

>

> *Don't ask permission to send a Change Order. You're not asking if it's okay to charge for the work — you're informing them that a Change Order is coming. This is the professional standard, and most clients will respond normally.*

>

> *Clients who react badly to a Change Order for legitimate out-of-scope work are telling you something. It usually means they expected you to absorb the extra work for free, which means it will keep happening. That's a client relationship problem, not a Change Order problem.*

>

> *The optional line at the bottom is useful when the new request reveals a gap in your original scope discussion. It opens the door to recalibrating the relationship without assigning blame.*

EMAIL 5 — DEPOSIT REQUEST / PROJECT CONFIRMATION

Use this when: A client has verbally agreed to the project and you're formalizing the booking. Do not block out calendar dates or turn down other work until the deposit is received and the contract is signed.

Why send it: "We're definitely doing this" is not a booking. A signed contract and a deposit are a booking. This email starts the formalization process and sets a deadline that keeps the project moving forward.

Subject: `[Project Name]` — Agreement + Deposit

Hi `[Name]`,

Great — glad we're moving forward on `[Project Name]`.

Attached are:

1. **Freelance Services Agreement** — covers the full scope, rate, and deliverables we discussed.
2. **Invoice #** `[INV-DEP-001]` — deposit of `$[Amount]` (`[X]`% of total project rate).

To confirm the booking:

- Sign the Agreement and send back a copy.
- Submit the deposit via `[preferred payment method]`.

Once both are received, the dates are confirmed and I'll hold them.

A quick heads-up: I have `[a competing inquiry / limited availability]` around those dates. I'll hold them until `[Date — give 48–72 hours]`, after which I may need to take another booking.

`[Your Name]`

> ***Notes:***

>

> *The deadline line is not a bluff or a pressure tactic — it's a statement of fact. Your availability is finite. A client who said yes three days ago but still hasn't signed or paid has not actually committed, and you shouldn't treat them as if they have.*

>

> *"A competing inquiry" or "limited availability" are both fine to state if true. If you have another inquiry coming in for those dates, it's honest. If your calendar simply fills up and you need a decision, "limited availability" is fair.*

>

> *Never start work before the deposit is received. The deposit is not a formality — it's the signal that the client is committed. Clients who start work without a deposit and then cancel are a pattern, not a coincidence.*

>

> *If a new client says "we don't pay deposits," that's a negotiating position, not a rule. Your response: "I require a deposit on all new client projects — it's how I hold dates. Happy to discuss the project rate if that's a concern." Most professional clients won't push back. Those who do are telling you something.*

A NOTE ON TONE

All five of these emails share a register: direct, professional, unapologetic. There is no groveling, no excessive hedging, no over-explaining.

This tone is not cold. It is the tone of someone who knows their work has value and communicates accordingly.

Creatives are often socialized to apologize for asking to be paid, to soften rate conversations, to say "I totally understand" before every ask. None of that is in these templates. That language is an artifact of undervaluing yourself — and clients read it. Confidence in your communication signals confidence in your work.

If these emails feel too direct at first, send them anyway. The response will normalize it fast.

Prepared with The Rate Guide Freelancer's Contract Pack. therateguide.com